

241 CE MANI BEGINS PREACHING IN PERSIA

In the chaos caused by the fall of the Persian Parthian dynasty, new religious movements flourished. Mani, who had been raised among one such sect, the Mandeans, preached a new creed, combining elements of Zoroastrianism and Christianity, with an emphasis on the cosmic battle between good and evil. Manichaeism, which forbade its priests to marry, spread widely, gaining adherents in Persia and the Roman Empire.

▷ Writings of Mani, illuminated manuscript



249 CE



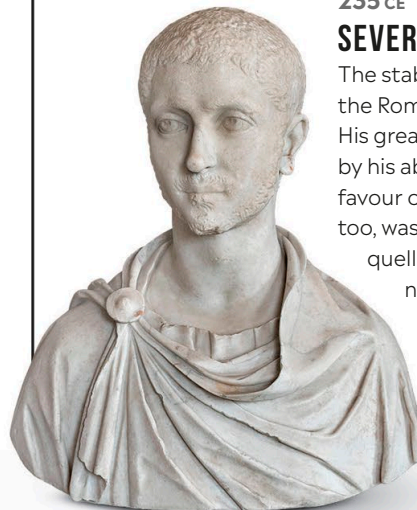
△ Investiture of Ardashir I,
stone relief

224 CE ARDASHIR OVERTHROWS THE PARTHIANS

The Parthian dynasty, rulers of Persia since the mid-3rd century BCE, had been weakened by Roman invasions and a civil war that divided the kingdom. After a Roman invasion in 216 CE, Ardashir, the local king of Pars in the southwest, revolted. Eight years later he defeated the last Parthian king, Artabanus V, to found a new dynasty, the Sasanians, that would rule Persia for the next four centuries.

235 CE Maximinus Thrax, a lowly soldier, becomes emperor, beginning the Military Anarchy period in the Roman Empire

249 CE The Sima clan seizes power in the Chinese kingdom of Cao Wei



235 CE SEVERUS ALEXANDER ASSASSINATED

The stability that Septimius Severus brought to the Roman Empire from 194 CE was short-lived. His great-nephew Elagabalus provoked a revolt by his aberrant behaviour, and was murdered in favour of his cousin, Severus Alexander. But he, too, was assassinated in 235 CE while trying to quell an army mutiny in Germany. Over the next half-century he was followed by over 25 short-lived emperors, many of them army officers.

◁ Severus Alexander